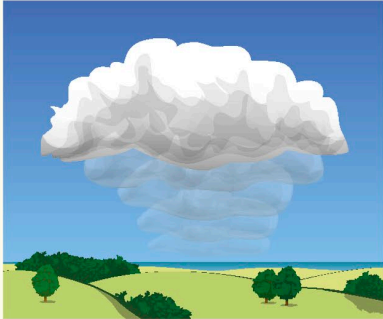


What makes a fluffy cloud?

Cumulus clouds form when sunshine warms up bubbles of moist air and causes them to rise quickly. As they get higher, they swell and are cooled so that the moisture turns into a mist of water droplets.

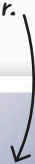


This cloud's fluffy shape shows how the bubble of warm, moist air billows out.

Cumulus clouds

Fluffy cumulus clouds are the clouds you usually see in clear weather, when the sky is blue. They look like heaps of cotton balls and are always changing shape. They are about 1,650 ft (500 m) above you.

Stratus clouds build up when warm, moist air rides up slowly over a bank of colder air.



Stratus clouds

The word “stratus” means “layers” in Latin, but you rarely see the layers in a stratus cloud. You just see a huge gray sheet of low cloud that can stretch for hundreds of miles.

